entry for reasons linked to shifting global geopolitics and growing great power rivalry. In an interview with the Chinese news agency *Xinhua* in June 2016, Russia's President Putin stated in a diplomatic manner: "The international environment is complicated and multifaceted, and issues are not resolved by the mere fact that countries with different approaches to and views on various international issues join the SCO creates conditions for those issues to be resolved."[21]

India's efforts to join the SCO came at a time when New Delhi was gradually aligning itself with the United States. In January 2015, the Modi government had indicated a strategic cooperation with the United States through their "Joint Strategic Vision for the Asia-Pacific and Indian Ocean Region." The US strategic vision of pivoting to the Asia-Pacific and the Indian Ocean Region is now being looked upon as a euphemism for a China containment strategy. In fact, since Prime Minister Modi attended the SCO Ufa Summit in 2015, Indo–US ties had only deepened further. Any ambiguity that may have existed so far in the Chinese mind was removed after Modi's visit to Washington in June 2016. Given the range of military and technological cooperation agreements signed, India's bilateral ties with the United States were then bound to grow to unprecedented levels.[22] The US decision to push for virtual "ally" status for India and India's willingness to sign the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement (LEMOA) may have slowed down the pace of India's entry into the SCO. China's negative approach to India's bid for membership in the Nuclear Supplier Group (NSG) in 2016 only added to this picture.[23] China preferred to wait and watch India's behaviour and intentions seeking membership in the SCO. India's confusion on its entry into the SCO was finally settled in 2017.